

DOWNTOWN

Sunday

February 15, 2026

THE HINDU

IT CORRIDOR

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A section of the rooftop solar installation at Bollineni Hillside off OMR.

Chennai RWA shines in TN's solar race

Bollineni Hillside has bagged an award for the biggest solar rooftop installation in Tamil Nadu in the category for resident welfare associations

PRINCE FREDERICK

Bollineni Hillside Phase I in Perumbakkam off Old Mahabalipuram Road sprawls across 45 acres and consists of 1295 dwelling units. For ease of administration, the community is cleaved in the middle, the north side servicing a half of those dwelling units and the south side the other half.

Both segments have a separate STP-WTP unit. These units are eminently useful, but are a criminal guzzler of energy, a fact that sticks out painfully when the EB bill arrives.

Sajeev Kumar, president of Bollineni Hillside Residential Township Owners Association (BHRTOA), estimates the community's monthly electricity bill at ₹10 lakh. "Electricity expense is one of the top three expenses," he points out.

The effort to whittle down that expense was launched recently, when the community had an operational solar power system in the end of January, 2026. The installation: a 97 kW solar system at one STP-WTP unit, and another 97 kW solar system at the other unit; a whopping 194 kW system in total. The decision to go solar first at these units was shaped by the consideration of significant savings on the EB bill as well as quicker recovery of the investment cost.

By virtue of going solar at this scale, BHRTOA has bagged an award from Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association (TNSEDA) for the biggest solar power installation in the RWA category across Tamil Nadu.

K. Thirugnanam, secretary, BHRTOA and an advocate, observes that the exercise synergies the various skillsets (BHRTOA president Sajeev is an IT professional) found within the community. To illustrate, he points out a retired senior official from the Tamil Nadu Electricity Board who is a resident of Bollineni Hillside was informally consulted to navigate regulatory nuances, particularly those pertaining to load thresholds and fixed charges that increase for installations exceeding 100 kW. Hence, the split into two units, each racking up 97 kW.



The question of subsidy processing

BHRTOA president Sajeev Kumar underlines the toughest part of the effort: settling on a vendor. Our vice-president Senthil Prabhu visited many RWAs that have gone solar, including those in Coimbatore.

BHRTOA treasurer Senthil Kumar S reveals that the vendor finally brought on board was found through the Federation of OMR Residents Association (FOMRRA). Senthil Kumar explains: "I had

posted a message in the FOMRRA group that we were looking for an empanelled solar rooftop installation vendor. And in the group I had also asked if anyone installed rooftop solar systems and got a subsidy for it. The overwhelming response was 'we installed, but we did not get the subsidy'. And one member in the group pointed us to this vendor who was known for diligent and effective subsidy processing."

BHRTOA secretary K. Thirug-

nanam says the selected solar energy company, Vesat Renewables Private Limited, based in Coimbatore has had a presence in the solar space for multiple decades, starting back then with solar water heaters and extending all the way to rooftop solar installations now. Contrary to the views held by many other vendors that had been approached earlier, this one was aware that RWAs were eligible for subsidy under PM's Surya Ghar Scheme. And BHRTOA was convinced of the company's end-to-end execution capability, particularly subsidy processing.

In sheer numbers

Estimating the cost of things under the sun is Senthil Kumar S's bailiwick as he is a chartered accountant. And he is particularly interested in working out the cost analysis of the solar endeavour at BHRTOA Phase I as he is its treasurer.

Here is what this exercise means to the community, in sheer numbers, as propounded by Senthil.

Installed capacity: 194 kW
Gross project cost: ₹1.1-1.2 crore

Subsidy received under centre's PM Surya Ghar scheme: **₹35 lakh**

Net investment: ₹85 lakh

Estimated annual savings: **₹25 lakh**

Expected payback: **3.5 to 4 years**

Assumed panel life: **25 years**

Estimated 25-year savings: **₹7 plus crore**

Senthil proceeds to do an ROI analysis:

*If ₹1 crore were placed in a fixed deposit (at approximately 7.5% annual return), the amount to flow in would be ₹7.5 lakh, which would be taxable.

*In contrast, the solar investment promises ₹25 lakh annual savings at a 25% return; and these are non-taxed operational savings.



From the awards ceremony.

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Reading space at gated community reopened

BOOK LOVERS OF DLF GARDEN CITY

At DLF GardenCity in Semmanchery, what had long remained a locked room prompted a simple question: could it be put to use again? The answer to the question: the reopening of a long-in-disuse library on January 26. The purpose of the exercise limited in scope, but clear in its focus. The space would be rededicated to reading; no frills attached to it, no plans to have the room doubling as a space for special activities.

This move at the gated community follows an article in *The Hindu Downtown* where a resident

had that expressed her wish for 2026 was to see the community library space better utilised. A small group of volunteers began discussions on reopening the space.

Since then, it has been kept open every weekend for two hours and has gradually begun to witness regular use.

Children now form a regular group of visitors; and they are usually accompanied by their parents. Some browse the shelves and choose from the library's collection, and children are encouraged to bring their own books if they wish to spend time reading in the quiet space. Parents often read alongside their children, making



Children now constitute a regular group of visitors to the library. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



the visit a shared reading experience rather than a supervised activity.

The library functions strictly as a reading-only space. While the collection is largely oriented towards children, a small number of books are available for adults as well.

An encouraging aspect of the reopening has been the response from the wider community. Several residents have come forward to donate books. These contributions

have strengthened the sense that the library is a shared space, shaped and sustained by its users.

Looking ahead, there are plans to extend the library's role through simple reading-related activities and events, while continuing to preserve its quiet character. Work is also underway on a mechanism that would allow residents within the community to share books more easily among themselves.

Tree remains



▼ The raintree at Besant Avenue Road was standing half dead for an inordinately long time, having been split in the middle. It was an obvious threat to public safety, and had to be removed. *The Hindu Downtown* had highlighted this in its pages. But the tree stayed on. Removed and dead now, the tree lingers on, part of the remains remaining uncleared on the road for weeks now. A barricade has been placed next to the remains to warn motorists. What is coming in the way of the remains being carted away? The roots and buttress of a tree that fell during the NE monsoon in 2025 continues to stay on as an unwelcome guest on the pavement of PS Kumaraswamy Raja Salai, near the Madras High Court Guest House. The images were taken on February 13 and 10, 2026 respectively.

PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

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LB ROAD, ADYAR

The evolution of the bins.



LIFFY THOMAS

If waste segregation is still not part of the daily routine in your home, then get ready to fall in line. New rules are coming into effect on April 1, 2026. Under the revised Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules 2026, notified recently by the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, four-stream segregation of solid waste at source has been made mandatory. This means your household waste is required to be segregated into wet waste, dry waste, sanitary waste and special care waste; the later includes paint cans, bulbs, mercury thermometers and medicines.

The revised rules, which supersedes Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016, integrate the principles of circular economy and extended producer responsibility, with a specific focus on waste segregation and management.

Those working in this space say some major concerns in Chennai include gaps in availability collection vehicles and processing facilities. There is also a need to enforce rules strictly for all stakeholders.

All bulk waste generators are expected to process wet waste *in situ* or obtain an Extended Bulk Waste Generator Responsibility (EBWGR) certificate stating that on-site processing is not feasible.

Material recovery facilities (MRFs) are again in the spotlight. Under the revised rules, local bodies are responsible for the collection, segregation and transportation of solid waste in coordination with MRFs which may also act as deposition points for e-waste, special care waste, sanitary waste and other waste streams for further processing. MRFs have been formally recognised as facilities for sorting of solid waste, says the note.

Local bodies have been encouraged to generate carbon credits.

Local bodies

The new rules emphasises creation of a Centralised On-line Portal to track all stages of solid waste management, including waste generation,

transportation, processing and disposal, as well as biomineral and bioremediation of legacy waste dump sites. Registration and authorisation of waste processing facilities with local bodies and State Pollution Control Boards or Pollution Control Committees shall be carried out online through the portal developed by the CPCB.

The rules mandate audits of all waste processing facilities.

Take four

Here is what a cross-section of people from the city have to say about the revised Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules 2026; the highlight is a four-bin system



VOICES

'Bulk generators must set an example'

Maintaining one more bin is going to be cumbersome for some residents, but it is just about getting used to the practice. We will be meeting to discuss how to bring about awareness about the new rules and how this new system can improve recycling efficiency and reducing landfill waste.

Currently, we follow the two bins, one bag method to collect waste. They were bought in bulk and given to residents for better compliance and uniformity. As in the past, we will have to educate all stakeholders about the rules. It is about consistent conversations and enforcement. Bulk waste generators like us have more reasons to follow rules and keep the city clean.

Our onsite composting has been had a hiatus and I hope the new rules will nudge us into finding new solutions to the challenges we faced in the past.

Sumitha Iyer, waste segregation team, The Central Park South and committee lead, FOMRRA Swacch Bharat

Bulk generators

Bulk waste generator includes entities with a floor area of **20,000 square metres** or more, or water consumption of **40,000 litres** per day or more, or solid waste generation of **100 kg** per day or more.

'We need to conduct awareness sessions'

The new SWM Rules 2026 lays emphasis on the responsibilities of all stakeholders in keeping a city clean by giving only segregated waste. It is possible to follow the four-bin system and we will start conducting awareness sessions. The battery-operated vehicles can accommodate eight bins, so it is just about having some systems in place. Managing sanitary waste is a challenge and if residents are responsible in the way they dispose of sanitary waste, then we will ensure it is taken to the incinerator.

Official, SWM, GCC

'Have stringent rules in place'

While I welcome four-way segregation of waste, I wonder how many of the current waste collection vehicles seen on Chennai roads have space to accommodate multiple bins. Local bodies must set aside dedicated days when different kinds of waste are collected and this must be communicated to residents so that segregation becomes a habit. When we worked in various neighbourhoods in the past, we had pressed separate vehicles into service for dry and wet waste. Stringent rules should be enforced to make contractors/waste management companies fall in line. I wished the revised rules had insisted that big housing projects create infrastructure for composting of waste before handing over the project to residents.

Mangalam Balasubramaniam, expert on solid waste management and founding president of Eco Chakra Abhiyan

'We will tweak our waste management rules'

Aashiana Apartment in Alwarpet is among the first gated communities in Chennai to start composting thanks to the small infrastructure created by the builder and the many programmes that we residents ran to get people to give only segregated waste. Even today our biodegradable waste is composted *in situ*. But we will have to tweak our waste management process as per the new SWM rules. Sanitary waste is currently included in dry waste. The new rules coming into force are only going to make it easier for us to enforce our segregation rules. Sadly non-compliance wittingly or otherwise happens at times and we have to keep reinforcing the rules.

Anita Hegde, Green Club volunteer, Aashiana Apartment

Velachery firemen **rescue** elderly couple



S. KUMARARAJA

On the night of February 7, an elderly couple residing at an apartment in Puzhuthivakkam were gripped with anxiety until fire service personnel arrived on the scene. The husband had fallen beside the bed, and his bedridden wife, unable to help him, reached for her mobile phone and sought assistance from a neighbour. The neighbour then called the fire service, who swiftly arrived at the scene and opened the main door of the couple's home, which was locked from the inside. The firefighters from the Velachery station of Tamil Nadu Fire & Rescue Services lifted the elderly man, who had sustained minor injuries, and administered first-aid. The prompt response of the fire service personnel earned the appreciation of residents from the neighbourhood.

S. Kumararaja is the president of Annai Indira Nagar Residents Welfare Association in Velachery

Healthcare facility upgraded

The Velachery area in Chennai (South) received a healthcare upgrade with the opening of Olir Super Speciality Hospital. The hospital, formerly known as Xcellent Care Hospital, has a state-of-the-art theatre, CT scanner, high-end C-arm, 4K arthroscopy system, spine microscope, and a 24/7 anaesthetist team for neurology, neurosurgery, orthopedics, urology, gastroenterology, paediatrics, and other emergencies, according to a release.

You can be our **volunteer writer**

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

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Women **achievers** awarded

Three young women achievers received validation of their journey and momentum for their journey ahead as they were presented with the M.O.P. Yuva Sammaan Awards in its eighth edition at a glittering ceremony on February 12 at M.O.P. Vaishnav College for Women.

International swimmer Bhavya Sachdeva, Asian medalist and national champion; entrepreneur Ranjani K Vivek, founder of Playtoddz Montessori, an innovative company that manufactures educational accessories and toys out of sustainable material for the Montessori school system; and Bharatanatyam artiste Lekha Prasad, classical dancer and teacher at Shri Silambam Academy of Fine Arts, each received a citation and ₹1 lakh, said a release.

Chess Grandmaster R. Vaishali was honoured with a special award.



**LITTLE SOI, BESANT NAGAR:
A WALK THROUGH ASIA BY THE SEA**



In a city that has steadily grown into one of India's most exciting dining destinations, it

takes something truly distinctive to arrest the attention of Chennai's seasoned culinary audience. The opening of Little Soi in Besant Nagar manages to do just that—not through excess or spectacle, but through a thoughtful marriage of location, cuisine, and character.

At the heart of Little Soi Besant Nagar lies its menu—an expansive, carefully curated selection that draws inspiration from the streets of South East Asia. Each section reflects a particular culinary geography, allowing diners to traverse borders with ease. A pan-Asian spread where fiery Thai heat, herb-bright Vietnamese notes, slow-spiced Indonesian

depth, comforting Chinese flavours, and refined Japanese subtlety come together on the plate.

For those who view dining as an exploration rather than a routine, this new Little Soi offers a compelling reason to visit. Against the backdrop of the Indian Ocean, with a menu that journeys across Asia, it quietly asserts itself as one of the city's most engaging new dining spaces—particularly for those seeking a memorable lunch by the sea.

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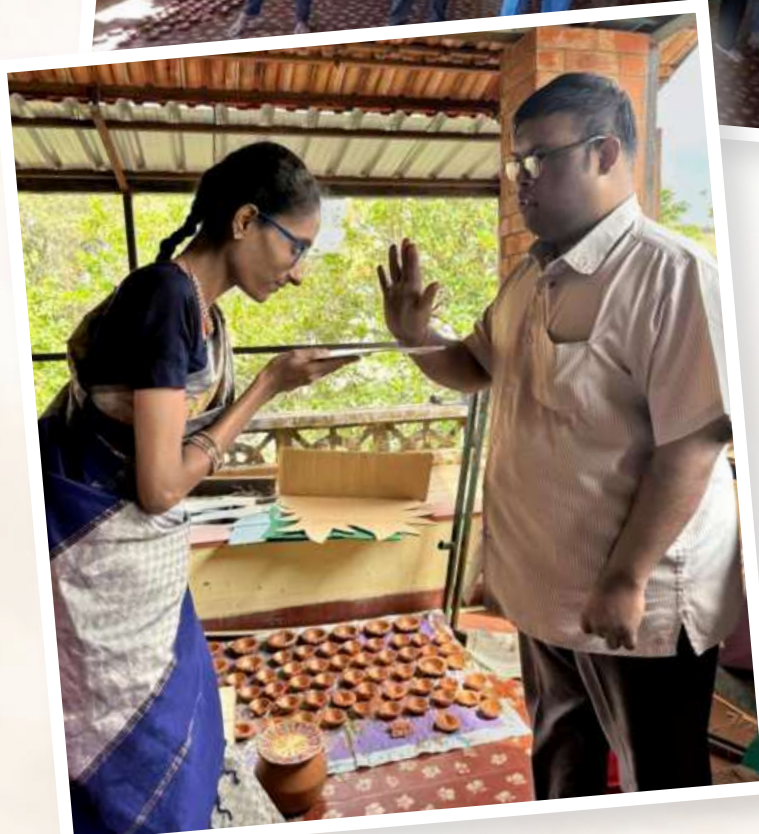
A major role off stage

A theatrical production at Narada Gana Sabha on February 20 featuring close to 300 differently abled participants is looking for volunteers. Read on and find out if you will fit the bill

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Ramana Sunritya Aalaya (RASA), an RA Puram-based organisation that takes the benefits of arts to special children, is calling for volunteers to run various errands for it as it gears up for its annual day celebration on February 20.

Close to 300 children, young adults and adults from seven schools with differing abilities are participating in this theatrical production titled “Veeram – Stories of Courage”, written and directed by its founder and director Ambika Kameshwar. Those who sign up as volunteers would be required to take the participants on to the stage, carry out backstage coordination, assist with costumes and offer prop assistance, help with stage movement and also attend to details pertaining to



Scenes from the rehearsals.

Participating centres

- Andhra Mahila Sabha
- Durgabai Deshmukh Association
- Mathru Mandir (DSFI) Pathway Special School
- RASA Ramana Sunritya Aalaya
- The Grove School Saraswati Kendra
- Dr. MGR School and Home for the Hearing and Speech Impaired
- MGR Janaki College - Section for the Hearing and Speech Impaired
- and Vijay Vidya Nursery and Primary School

stage production.

Those with patience, openness, love for the arts and a caring heart for special children, and presence of mind can sign up as volunteer, says RASA. By virtues of the roles assigned to them, they have the power to create a joyful experience for students and parents.

College students, parents, alumni, educators, theatre practitioners and professionals can sign up either for a few hours of volunteering or for all three days. Rehearsals are happening on February 18 and 19 and the final day is February 20. Once volunteers register, they will be invited for an orientation and on-ground guidance.

Vaishnavi Poorna, deputy director of the organisations, says RASA Day is a culmination of the year-long learning of our students.

Before Ambika Kameshwar started her own institute, she used to function as a facilitator to other special schools in the city and offer the students movement therapy. “This continues even today and the services are offered free, so these special schools have been associated with us for many years,” she says.

The two-hour production will feature seven stories from Indian spiritual mythology and will be staged at Narada Gana Sabha in Alwarpet.

Considerable characterisation goes into the role played by every participant.

“If a child is diffident about something then we give him a role where he will understand what it is to be in the shoes of the character, so they learn to apply it to real life,” she says.

For details, call 9840139607. Volunteer registration form is available at <https://forms.gle/VcGz8YNTkdPebUM6>

Residents given ‘star billing’ at community event

Rani Meyammai Towers in MRC Nagar stages a two-night Oscar-themed cultural event



Snapshots of the event.

RMT Extravaganza 2026, a resident-led cultural programme, was held over two evenings (February 7 and 8) at Rani Meyammai Towers in MRC Nagar, drawing significant participation from the community. Organised around an “Oscar Night” theme, the event featured a coordi-

nated ramp walk, music and dance performances and theatrical presentations, says a press release.

Children, women and men from the residential complex participated in curated segments: Indo-Western fashion presentations, folk and contemporary dance routines, musical medleys and short skits

among others. The men’s ramp walk was exclusively sponsored by Indian Terrain, while the fashion segments were conceptualised and coordinated by Iris Events, the release adds.

Residents said the two-day programme was marked by volunteer

involvement across age groups.

Writer and Padma Shri awardee Sivasankari; entrepreneur and founder of Aircel and mentor at AI-WO.com C. Sivasankaran; and Mrs. Earth International 2017 Anu Alex attended as guests. Organisers said their presence encouraged partici-

pants and added visibility to the programme.

The event was supported by sponsors including Prestige Group, HDFC Bank, Karur Vysya Bank, Chennai Diamonds and other community partners, the press release adds.

Workshop on drone operations



Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu, conducted a three-day training programme on drone operations at its premises in Guindy. PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B

A lively space in Thiruvannmiyur for kids

Designed as a kids' play and pre-school space, Toddler Playhouse in Thiruvannmiyur offers an engaging environment for toddlers.

According to a press release, what truly sets Toddler Playhouse apart is its spacious outdoor play area, packed with fun-filled physical activities that encourage movement, coordination and social interaction.

From climbing and running to imaginative group games, children are constantly engaged in healthy, active play. The venue has also emerged as a popular birthday party destination, ideal for host-

ing small groups of children, says a press release. With ample outdoor space, age-appropriate play equipment and a cheerful setting, birthday celebrations here are lively, stress-free and memorable for both children and parents, the release adds.

Admissions are open for play group and pre kg. Or just drop in for an unfiltered fun playtime, whatever suits your toddler, says the press release.

Toddler Playhouse is located at 13/25, 3rd East Street Kamaraj Nagar Thiruvannmiyur- 41 (Ground floor of Season 4 Residences). For details, call 95510 60099/ 88254 57667

Workshop on making ice-creams from millets



Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu, is organizing a training programme on making ice creams from wheat and millets. It will be held from February 19 to 20.

Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. at the centre's premises at No: 1, EDII Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Ekkaduthangal, Guindy. For details, call 8668102600 / 8754495254.

A lecture on Parkinson's in Besant Nagar

Parivarthan for Parkinson's Foundation is hosting a special lecture on Understanding and Managing Parkinson's on February 22 at 11:00 am at The Learning Community at Quest in Besant Nagar.

The session will be led by Dr. M. R. Murali, M.B.B.S., M.D., an allergist and immunologist at Massachusetts General Hospital and Harvard Medical School, Boston. Parkinson's is a progressive neurological disorder with no known cure. This session aims to equip attendees with essential knowledge about Parkinson's, address common misconceptions, and highlight practical approaches to managing it over time.

The event is open to people with Parkinson's, caregivers, healthcare professionals and anyone interested in learning more about the condition. To attend, register by calling or messaging +91 96000 52531.



Training session on gold appraisal

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is organising a workshop on gold appraisal from February 16 to 20 at its premises at No: 1, EDII Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Ekkaduthangal, Guindy. Time From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

According to a press release, the session covers the following: concepts in metallurgy with focus on gold and silver, difference between karat and carat, methods for calculating gold purity, and jewel loan assessment procedures.

Hands-on training in jewellery making is also part of the programme. Hallmarking procedures and standards will be covered. The programme aims to prepare the participants to set up an enterprise in gem and jewellery sector. Further, they will find part-time job opportunities in banks as gold assayer, adds the press release.

Those aged 18 years and above with a minimum qualification of class 10 can apply. Hostel facility is available at first-come, first-served basis. Prior registration is mandatory.

For details, call 9360221280 / 8668100181.

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